

Desistance Section Source Sheet: Chapter 1, Section 4 (Updated)

Focus: Chapter 1, Section 4 — Desistance from crime Purpose of this sheet: practical source-and-quote bank for drafting the desistance section of the dissertation literature review, using the updated outline and updated literature notes as the primary source of truth. Primary base used: Lit_Review_Outline_1_1_1_1---6dfca873-828f-41f5-bc72-8c1389b8c86c.txt and Literature_Notes_4---d57e6617-920b-4a13-b2cc-49891fb6eb36.txt, supplemented only with a small number of peer-reviewed empirical/open-access sources where needed.

Important use note: Quotes below are taken either from the updated notes or from accessible open sources explicitly identified below. Quotes from the notes should still be verified against the original full text/page before final dissertation submission. I did not invent quotes.

Quick framing for the section

A clean way to write this section is to argue that desistance is not a single event but a process involving at least three interrelated layers:

- 1 Behavioral change — reduced offending or a lull/cessation in crime.
- 2 Identity change — seeing oneself as a different kind of person.
- 3 Social reintegration — gaining belonging, recognition, and legitimate community membership.

For your dissertation, the strongest move is to connect desistance theory to emerging adulthood: this life stage is already marked by identity exploration, unstable transitions, peer sensitivity, and delayed access to adult roles, so it is a particularly important window for interventions meant to promote desistance.

1. Conceptualizing desistance

Framing idea for this subsection

Open by defining desistance as a dynamic and nonlinear process rather than a one-time outcome. Then distinguish primary, secondary, and tertiary desistance. End the subsection by noting that the field still lacks agreement on how desistance should be defined and measured.

Source 1

Citation: Maruna, S. (2003). Desistance from crime: A theoretical reformulation. In W. H. Heitmeyer & J. Hagan (Eds.), *International Handbook of Violence Research* (or related reprint source; verify final dissertation citation format).

Why relevant: This is one of the foundational conceptual sources for understanding desistance as more than simple nonoffending. It is especially useful for framing desistance as a process rather than a terminal event.

Direct quote(s):

- From the updated notes: “The word desistance does not refer to a termination event that takes place at the time of a last offense. Desistance is the process of refraining or abstaining, from illegal behavior.”

Brief summary: Maruna’s work is central for shifting desistance scholarship away from a narrow “last offense” view and toward a process model. This is important for dissertation framing because it prevents the section from collapsing desistance into a simple recidivism count.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source early to define desistance as a process of movement away from crime, which sets up later discussion of identity, social bonds, and reintegration.

Source 2

Citation: Maruna, S., & Farrall, S. (2004). Desistance from crime: A theoretical reformulation. [verify final publication details].

Why relevant: This is the best-known conceptual anchor for distinguishing primary and secondary desistance.

Direct quote(s):

- From the updated notes summarizing the literature review by Sagara et al. (2024): “Maruna proposed 2 distinct phases of desistance: primary and secondary.”
- From search-accessible source language located during review: primary desistance refers to “a period of non-offending,” while secondary desistance refers to “a change in self-identity where the person no longer thinks of themselves as an offender.” Verify exact wording in original source before direct dissertation quotation.

Brief summary: Primary desistance refers to a lull or cessation in offending behavior. Secondary desistance refers to a shift in self-concept—moving from merely not offending to viewing oneself as a changed person. This distinction is highly relevant to a treatment manual because it suggests that behavior management alone is not enough.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to argue that a desistance-oriented correctional intervention should target not only behavior but also identity transformation, future orientation, and meaning-making.

Source 3

Citation: McNeill, F. (2015). Work on tertiary desistance / reintegration / belonging [verify exact source used in final dissertation].

Why relevant: This is the key conceptual source for adding tertiary desistance, which is especially useful for your dissertation because your proposed intervention is aimed at long-term reintegration, not just in-facility

behavior.

Direct quote(s):

- From the updated notes: “Mcneill (2015) offered an additional phase called tertiary desistance, which involves not just shifts in behaviors or identity but shifts in ones sense of belonging to a community.”
- From the updated notes: “Tertiary desistance is based on the assumption that society tolerates ex offenders.”

Brief summary: Tertiary desistance extends the desistance concept beyond the individual and emphasizes recognition, social acceptance, and belonging. This perspective is important because someone may stop offending and even adopt a new identity, yet still struggle if the community continues to cast them only as an offender.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to support the point that sustainable desistance depends partly on social reintegration, reduced stigma, and legitimate inclusion.

Source 4

Citation: Sagara, B., et al. (2024). Mapping desistance research: A systematic quantitative literature review from 2011 to 2020.

Why relevant: This is one of the best updated-note sources for summarizing the state of the desistance field and its definitional variability.

Direct quote(s):

- “The variability in desistance research is attributed to differing operationlisations of desistance.”
- “Rocque (2017) argues that defining desistance determines the methodology and interpretation of desistance gradual and dynamic process that involves lapses and relapses of offending until complete cessation.”
- “In most studies primary desistance was the most frequently used, accounting for 79.6%, followed by secondary desistance 41.3% and tertiary desistance 4.6%.”
- “The dearth of tertiary desistance literature is partly because it is new relative to primary and secondary desistance.”

Brief summary: This review shows that desistance scholarship has expanded quickly, but not uniformly. Primary desistance dominates, secondary desistance is less common, and tertiary desistance is still relatively rare. That imbalance matters because it shows how often the field privileges behavioral change over identity and reintegration.

Suggested use in writing: Use this as a recent synthesis source to show that the field is growing, but that its concepts and measures remain uneven and fragmented.

Source 5

Citation: Massoglia, M., & Uggen, C. (2007). Subjective desistance and the transition to adulthood. *Journal of Contemporary Criminal Justice*, 23(1), 90–103. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC2441929/>

Why relevant: This is one of the strongest supplemental empirical sources for the measurement problem and the emerging-adulthood angle.

Direct quote(s):

- “This paper introduces two new conceptualizations of desistance based on individuals’ personal assessments of their own movement away from crime.”
- “The results indicate that the prevalence and the predictors of desistance vary with these alternative conceptualizations.”
- “While relationship quality is consistently related to each desistance measure, the effects of prior crime, peer relationships, race, gender, and parental status depend upon the outcome under consideration.”

Brief summary: Massoglia and Uggen show that desistance looks different depending on whether it is measured through arrests, self-report, or subjective self-assessment. This is highly useful for your limitations subsection because it provides direct empirical support for the claim that measurement decisions shape findings.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source when you transition from conceptual definitions of desistance to the methodological problem that the field often treats different outcomes as if they were interchangeable.

Source 6

Citation: Robertson, A. A., et al. (2022). Recidivism Among Justice-Involved Youth: Findings From JJ-TRIALS.

Why relevant: This source gives very clear language for the lack of consensus around recidivism, which often functions as a stand-in for desistance.

Direct quote(s):

- “Measuring and reporting recidivism is vital for tracking probation outcomes; for evaluating the effectiveness of interventions; and for informing JJ policy, practice, and resource allocation, yet no consensus exists with respect to defining recidivism or the length of follow-up period for determining occurrences of recidivism.”
- “The definition, the length of the tracking period, and youth characteristics used influence recidivism rates differently.”
- “Recidivism rates can vary considerably across studies, by state, within the same state, and even among neighborhoods within a single municipality.”

Brief summary: This study underscores that recidivism is not a stable, universally measured construct. Because desistance research frequently relies on recidivism metrics, this inconsistency has downstream effects on interpretation.

Suggested use in writing: Use this to strengthen the argument that there is still no universally accepted way to operationalize successful desistance or even reoffending.

2. Factors that promote desistance

Framing idea for this subsection

A strong synthesis here is that desistance is promoted by a combination of cognitive/identity shifts, social bonds, prosocial roles such as employment and education, and engagement in effective treatment/support systems. The cleanest way to write this is to emphasize that desistance is neither purely internal nor purely structural—it is a developmental and relational process.

A. Identity shifts and cognitive transformation

Source 7

Citation: Giordano, P. C., Cernkovich, S. A., & Rudolph, J. L. (2002). Gender, crime, and desistance: Toward a theory of cognitive transformation. *American Journal of Sociology*, 107(4), 990–1064.

Why relevant: This is one of the classic desistance sources for cognitive openness, hooks for change, and identity transformation.

Direct quote(s):

- No verbatim quote pulled from open full text in this session; use as a major conceptual/empirical source and verify direct quotations from the original article before final use.

Brief summary: Giordano et al. argue that desistance involves cognitive openness to change, exposure to hooks for change, and transformation in how individuals interpret themselves and their lives. This makes it one of the strongest empirical/theoretical supports for your argument that interventions should actively target identity and cognition.

Suggested use in writing: Use this as a backbone source when discussing why desistance-oriented programming should include cognitive restructuring, future planning, and meaning-making—not just behavioral compliance.

Source 8

Citation: Copp, J. E., Giordano, P. C., Longmore, M. A., & Manning, W. D. (2020). Desistance from crime during the transition to adulthood: The influence of parents, peers, and shifts in identity. *Journal of Research in Crime and Delinquency*, 57(3), 294–332. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7946401/>

Why relevant: This is one of the strongest supplemental empirical studies for your chapter because it directly links desistance to the transition to adulthood.

Direct quote(s):

- “Findings indicated that identity changes were associated with declines in offending.”

- “Changes in parental closeness and the extent of affiliation with antisocial peers contributed to patterns of offending, net of these subjectively experienced cognitive changes.”
- “Cognitive processes are important to desistance. However, they do not independently provide a path to sustained behavioral change.”
- “Social experiences, including changes in relationships/supports from parents and affiliation with delinquent peers, also figure into change processes.”

Brief summary: This study is especially useful because it shows that identity change matters, but is not sufficient by itself. Social relationships—especially closeness with parents and reduced antisocial peer involvement—also help shape whether desistance is sustained.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to support a sentence like: desistance among young adults appears to involve both subjective cognitive change and shifts in the social ecology surrounding the individual.

Source 9

Citation: Maruna, S. (2004). Desistance from crime and explanatory style: A new direction in the psychology of reform.

Why relevant: This source helps connect desistance to narrative identity, explanatory style, and cognitive self-understanding.

Direct quote(s):

- “The word desistance does not refer to a termination event that takes place at the time of a last offense. Desistance is the process of refraining or abstaining, from illegal behavior.”
- “Negative internal attributions are associated with persisting in criminal bx.”
- “One can speculate that the more individuals are able to attribute positive life events to broad, long lasting personal qualities, the greater the odds may be that they will be able to stay crime free.”
- “One of the most significant findings in psychology in the last 20 years is that individuals can choose the way they think.”

Brief summary: Maruna links desistance to explanatory style and the stories people tell themselves about change. This matters because persistent criminal behavior may be reinforced by stable, global, negative self-beliefs, whereas desistance may be facilitated by a more hopeful, future-oriented narrative.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to support the dissertation’s rationale for interventions that target cognition, self-story, and perceived agency.

B. Social bonds, family support, and peers

Source 10

Citation: Mowen, T. J., et al. (2018). A developmental perspective on reentry: understanding the causes and consequences of family conflict and peer delinquency during adolescence and emerging adulthood.

Why relevant: This is one of the strongest updated-note sources for showing that desistance is shaped by post-release social context.

Direct quote(s):

- “Post release social context matters more than past bx alone. Family conflict and peers independently increase offending even after controlling for prior offending.”
- “Family conflict and delinquent peers are shared risk factors for criminal offending and substance use (peer effects are particularly strong).”
- “Strong post-release family support reduces family conflict and indirectly reduces peer delinquency and recidivism risk.”
- “Interventions should prioritize family-based reentry programs, address family conflict immediately post-release, and target peer network restructuring.”

Brief summary: Mowen and colleagues show that what happens after release matters tremendously, especially for younger populations. Family conflict and delinquent peers operate as important persistence risks, while strong family support can indirectly reduce reoffending.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source when arguing that desistance is strongly influenced by relational context and should not be framed as a purely individual choice.

Source 11

Citation: Matsueda, R. L. (2001). Differential association theory.

Why relevant: This gives the theory mechanism for why peer change matters.

Direct quote(s):

- “Criminal behavior occurs when definitions favorable to crime outnumber or outweigh definitions unfavorable to crime.”
- “Criminal behavior is most likely when individuals are deeply embedded in social networks that normalize, justify, or encourage law-breaking behavior.”

Brief summary: Differential association theory explains offending as learned behavior acquired through social interaction. In desistance terms, this implies that reduced involvement with antisocial peers and increased access to prosocial relationships should matter for staying crime-free.

Suggested use in writing: Use this as the theory support underneath the empirical sources on peers and reentry.

C. Employment, education, and adult-role transitions

Source 12

Citation: [Verify exact citation] Is emerging adulthood influencing Moffitt's developmental taxonomy? Adding the prolonged adolescent offender?

Why relevant: This is one of the strongest updated-note sources for linking delayed adult-role transitions to continued low-level offending in emerging adulthood.

Direct quote(s):

- "Prolonged adolescent offender: low level offender between the ages of 18 and 25 that has failed to successfully transition into adult social roles."
- "The prolonged adolescent offender engages in crime and deviance because of failure to breach the maturity gap and achieve adult status, as symbolized by reaching the turning points of marriage, stable employment, and completion of higher educations."
- "The # of hours worked per week were also a significant predictor of low-level offending, with those who worked more hours having lower levels of offending."
- "Economic instability was related to both low-level offending and drug use, with those having higher level of economic instability having higher expected counts of both behaviors."

Brief summary: This source frames some emerging-adult offending as the product of delayed, blocked, or unstable transition into adult roles. Stable work, education, and conventional role attainment therefore appear relevant to desistance.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to argue that employment and education matter not just instrumentally but developmentally—they mark movement into prosocial adult identity.

Source 13

Citation: Eitle, D., et al. (2010). General strain theory, persistence, and desistance among young adult male offenders. [verify exact citation details].

Why relevant: This study is useful because it explicitly addresses desistance in young adults and connects it to strain reduction and coping.

Direct quote(s):

- "Agnew suggested that adults who fail to find loving relationships, get decent jobs, and marshal the resources necessary to make changes in their lives that reduce exposure to negative events and relations will likely not experience fewer strains in adulthood."
- "GST suggests that desistance is more likely to occur among adults experiencing fewer negative events and negative relationships."
- "The core GST relationship b/w strain and crime was also found to be an important predictor of desistance from criminal bx."

Brief summary: This source helps explain why stable relationships, fewer chronic stressors, and better coping resources may support desistance. It also adds theoretical diversity by bringing in a strain perspective focused on persistence versus desistance.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to show that desistance is partly promoted by reduced strain and improved coping capacity, not only by external controls.

D. Treatment engagement and structured support

Source 14

Citation: David, D. L., et al. (2016). Reducing recidivism and symptoms in emerging adults with serious mental health conditions and justice system involvement.

Why relevant: This is one of the strongest updated-note sources on intervention evidence that is specifically tied to emerging adulthood.

Direct quote(s):

- “There are really no established interventions with evidence of efficacy to reduce recidivism among emerging adults with or without SMHC.”
- “In a study, the specialized intervention group had better recidivism outcomes than the control group, highlighting the potential utility of targeting emerging adults’ unique developmental challenges in the context of recidivism reduction approaches.”
- “The primary goal of MST-EA are to reduce recidivism and support positive functioning in school, work, independent living, and relationships, while ensuring tx and management of mental illness and any co-occurring substance use disorder.”
- “The changes in ultimate outcomes for mental health sx and criminality were positive and, with one exception, statistically significant, even with a small sample size.”

Brief summary: This feasibility-focused work supports the idea that developmentally adapted intervention for justice-involved emerging adults can improve both criminal and mental health outcomes. It also directly supports your argument that the evidence base for this age group remains thin.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to make the point that age-tailored intervention is promising and probably necessary, especially when justice involvement co-occurs with mental health needs.

Source 15

Citation: Silva, M. J., et al. (2025). Effectiveness of Motivational Interviewing with justice-involved people: A systematic review and meta-analysis.

Why relevant: This is a strong source for treatment engagement, motivation, attendance, and dropout—factors that matter a lot in real-world correctional programming.

Direct quote(s):

- “When working with justice involved people, it is important to first increase their engagement in the process of change.”
- “MI appears to be an effective tool for managing this resistance by avoiding confrontation and promoting opportunities to enhance participants’ intrinsic motivation.”

- “Results from the meta-analysis indicated that MI was significantly more effective in reducing recidivism rates and increasing session attendance than interventions without MI.”
- “MI incorporation has shown to be more effective in increasing session attendance and reducing dropout than interventions without MI.”

Brief summary: This review suggests that motivational interviewing can improve engagement and may reduce recidivism, especially by reducing resistance and increasing session attendance. That is highly relevant to any manual for a population that may be skeptical, externally mandated, or ambivalent about treatment.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to justify including motivational strategies or MI-consistent engagement practices as part of the program model.

3. Gender and age considerations in desistance

Framing idea for this subsection

This subsection should argue that desistance is not fully generalizable across all populations. Developmental stage and gender shape risk exposure, social roles, treatment needs, and likely pathways toward desistance.

Source 16

Citation: Rice, S. M., et al. (2023). Unmet mental health and criminogenic needs among justice-involved young people: A role for clinicians in the community.

Why relevant: This is one of the best updated-note sources for developmental framing and for gender-responsive considerations.

Direct quote(s):

- “The onset of puberty (10-12) marks the commencement of a distinct developmental period that extends to around age 25 years and which supports the acquisition of the skills, self-regulatory capacities, and culturally embodied knowledge that are required to achieve independent adult role functioning and societal integration.”
- “Many justice involved young ppl living in the community fall through systemic cracks, often magnified by the mismatch b/w developmental (10-25) and legal definitions of this population.”
- “Approximately 80% of justice involved ppl aged <18 y/o are male, rising to 90% among young ppl in custody, although females are a fast-growing population in the youth justice system.”
- “With girls, a history of trauma is more common, warranting trauma-informed care and interventions promoting positive social relationships.”
- “The available research on gender sensitive interventions for girls and young women suggests that effective tx will target the negative cognitions and emotions that result from trauma with the aim of promoting more adaptive social functioning.”

Brief summary: Rice et al. frame justice-involved young people as a developmentally distinct population extending to roughly age 25. The article also shows that males dominate the system numerically, but girls and young women often present with heavier trauma-related needs requiring gender-sensitive intervention.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to justify your emphasis on young adults as a distinct developmental group and to support a paragraph on gender-responsive intervention needs.

Source 17

Citation: Denny, J., Connor, D., et al. (2016). Serious juvenile offenders who have experienced emerging adulthood: Substance use and recidivism. [verify exact citation details].

Why relevant: This source helps situate emerging adulthood as a distinct developmental period that may shape persistence versus desistance.

Direct quote(s):

- “Emerging adulthood: refers to a finite period of time, approximately b/w 18-25 years old, where youth in certain cultures go through distinct identity exploration/formation not found in any other age groups and in most other cultures.”
- “This period can even extend throughout the entire 20’s depending on the individual.”
- “Age of identity exploration.”
- “Age of instability.”
- “Age of feeling in-between.”
- “Age of possibilities.”

Brief summary: This source uses Arnett’s emerging-adulthood framework to explain why ages 18-25 should not simply be treated as “older adolescents” or “fully mature adults.” That matters because desistance opportunities and risks are embedded in this transition period.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to make the developmental case for why young adults require tailored correctional intervention rather than models designed either for juveniles or fully mature adults.

Source 18

Citation: [Verify exact citation] Is emerging adulthood influencing Moffitt’s developmental taxonomy? Adding the prolonged adolescent offender?

Why relevant: This source also contributes to age and gender considerations.

Direct quote(s):

- “Females have lower levels of offending.”
- “Female criminality peaks early in the life course and women offend, at least for the crimes measured in the study, less than men.”

- “It should be noted that some adolescent limited offenders may be ‘caught’ in the maturity gap and continue to offend. It is these individuals who are likely to continue to offend as prolonged adolescent offenders.”

Brief summary: This source supports the argument that age-graded offending patterns and gender differences matter when considering desistance. It also reinforces the relevance of the maturity-gap concept in emerging adulthood.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to help explain why desistance pathways may be different for emerging adults who have not yet successfully transitioned into adult roles.

Source 19

Citation: Silva, M. J., et al. (2025). Effectiveness of Motivational Interviewing with justice-involved people: A systematic review and meta-analysis.

Why relevant: This source is useful here because it explicitly flags the underdevelopment of the literature on women in justice settings.

Direct quote(s):

- “This highlights the urgent need for more research focusing exclusively on women and for interventions aimed directly at women, given the increasing conviction rates and the specificity of female criminal conduct, avoiding abusive generalizations of studies conducted with men.”
- “Understanding the unique trajectories of justice involved women is crucial to unravel the complexity of their experiences and to identify key factors that can influence risk an intervention outcomes.”

Brief summary: Even where intervention research exists, women are often underrepresented. This is directly relevant to your literature review because it shows that the evidence base on desistance and treatment engagement is still heavily male-centered.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source in the gender subsection or limitations subsection to show that female-specific desistance processes remain underexamined.

4. Empirical studies on desistance interventions

Framing idea for this subsection

This subsection should not oversell the intervention literature. The better argument is that some interventions show promise—especially when they are developmentally responsive, therapeutic rather than punitive, and engagement-oriented—but the evidence base remains uneven and often not specific to young adults in correctional settings.

Source 20

Citation: Lipsey, M. W., & Cullen, F. T. (2007). The effectiveness of correctional rehabilitation: A review of systematic reviews.

Why relevant: This is one of the strongest updated-note sources for the broad rehabilitation evidence base.

Direct quote(s):

- “Supervision and sanctions, at best, show modest mean reductions in recidivism and in some instances, have the opposite effect and increase reoffense rates.”
- “Prominent literature supports the conclusion that punishment has little or no effect on recidivism.”
- “The scared straight program and similar programs revealed that the intervention on average is more harmful to juveniles than doing nothing.”
- “In sum, research does not show that the aversive experience of receiving correctional sanctions greatly inhibits subsequent criminal behavior.”
- “Overall, what research is available now firmly establishes the general point that rehabilitation works.”
- “The most important task for the next generation of research is to address the question of when, why, and for whom it works best.”

Brief summary: This review is a strong anchor for arguing that punitive approaches are generally weak or harmful, while rehabilitation is more promising. It also supports the need for more precise research on which interventions work, for whom, and under what conditions.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to set up why your dissertation is justified: the field supports rehabilitation broadly, but still needs more developmentally specific, well-targeted models for young adults.

Source 21

Citation: Cullen, F. T. (2022 or relevant edition/chapter). Correctional rehabilitation. [verify exact source details].

Why relevant: This source helps connect the desistance literature to broader rehabilitation philosophy and practice.

Direct quote(s):

- “The challenge remains to implement evidence based treatment practices and more broadly, to create legal processes that afford offenders the opportunity to earn true redemption and thus escape the burdens of a criminal record.”
- “Correctional rehabilitation can be justified on moral grounds as a humane alternative to efforts to inflict pain on the convicted and for the investment it makes in offenders’ lives.”
- Rehabilitation is defined in the updated notes as “a planned correctional intervention that targets for change internal and/or social criminogenic factors with the goal of reducing recidivism and, where possibly of improving other aspects of an offenders life.”
- “Interventions that are therapeutic and emphasize a human service approach are most likely to achieve substantial reductions in recidivism.”

Brief summary: Cullen's work is useful for situating intervention within a broader human-service, rehabilitation-oriented model that is consistent with desistance principles. It is also helpful for arguing that desistance promotion should involve opportunity, support, and reintegration rather than punishment alone.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to frame your proposed manual as part of an evidence-based rehabilitative approach rather than a purely control-based correctional model.

Source 22

Citation: David, D. L., et al. (2016). Reducing recidivism and symptoms in emerging adults with serious mental health conditions and justice system involvement.

Why relevant: This is one of the few intervention studies in your updated notes that actually targets emerging adults.

Direct quote(s):

- "There are really no established interventions with evidence of efficacy to reduce recidivism among emerging adults with or without SMHC."
- "The specialized intervention group had better recidivism outcomes than the control group."
- "The changes in ultimate outcomes for mental health sx and criminality were positive and, with one exception, statistically significant, even with a small sample size."
- "41 participants so kind of a small study."

Brief summary: This study supports cautious optimism. It suggests that developmentally adapted interventions for emerging adults may improve outcomes, but the small sample size and feasibility focus limit generalizability.

Suggested use in writing: Use this as a concrete example of why emerging-adult intervention research is promising but still underdeveloped.

Source 23

Citation: Silva, M. J., et al. (2025). Effectiveness of Motivational Interviewing with justice-involved people: A systematic review and meta-analysis.

Why relevant: This source contributes to the intervention evidence by focusing on engagement and dropout—two major implementation issues in correctional settings.

Direct quote(s):

- "Justice involved ppl often approach intervention assessment with a lack of motivation to change and display argumentative behavior, impulsivity, and skepticism, and all of these factors can increase resistance to intervention and undermine its success."
- "MI showed greater effectiveness among men with low readiness to change and in the early stages of change."

- “Overall MI works. Dropout rates were high though.”
- “The integration of MI has proven to be effective in reducing recidivism rates.”

Brief summary: This review suggests that MI can help address one of the biggest practical barriers in justice settings: engagement. That makes it highly relevant for a dissertation proposing a real-world treatment manual.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source when discussing intervention components that may improve uptake, attendance, and retention.

Source 24

Citation: Zeccola, J., et al. (2021). Does the Good Lives Model work? A systematic review of the recidivism evidence.

Why relevant: This source is useful because it adds nuance and prevents overclaiming about strengths-based models.

Direct quote(s):

- “Despite the diverse application of the GLM, the efficacy of the model on its ability to lower recidivism outcomes has not been established and is the subject of ongoing debates.”
- “It was concluded there was no evidence to suggest that GLM could significantly reduce recidivism risk.”
- “As of June 2021, it appears given the published evidence the GLM cannot be purported to be an offender rehabilitation framework that is underpinned by evidence based practice that can reduce recidivism risk.”
- “There was limited evidence that the GLM had the ability to increase and sustain motivation for resistance from reoffending.”

Brief summary: This review is important because it shows that strengths-based/desistance-friendly models are appealing conceptually but do not always yet have strong recidivism evidence. That nuance will make your literature review more credible.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to show that motivational and strengths-based ideas may be useful, but they should not substitute for evidence-based programming principles.

Source 25

Citation: Andrews, D. A., Bonta, J., & Hoge, R. D. / Psychology of Criminal Conduct (RNR chapters; verify exact edition used).

Why relevant: This is the empirical backbone for why some interventions reduce recidivism and others do not.

Direct quote(s):

- “Higher risk offenders need more intensive and extensive services if we are to hope for a significant reduction in recidivism. For the low risk offender, minimal or even no intervention is sufficient.”
- “Providing intensive services to higher risk offenders was associated with an 18% reduction of recidivism for offenders in residential programs and a 9% reduction for offenders in nonresidential programs.”
- “Reductions in recidivism for high risk offenders were found only when intensive levels of services were provided. However, when intensive services were provided to low risk offenders, they had a negative effect.”
- “One should use social learning and cognitive behavioral styles of service to bring about change.”

Brief summary: RNR offers one of the most empirically supported frameworks for organizing intervention. It is especially useful in your section because it helps distinguish between interventions that are merely well-intentioned and those that are aligned with evidence on risk, need, and responsivity.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to support the argument that any desistance-promoting program for young adults should still be anchored in evidence-based correctional principles, not just broad rehabilitation ideals.

5. Limitations in the current desistance literature

Framing idea for this subsection

This subsection should be blunt: the desistance literature is valuable, but it remains limited by definition/measurement problems, uneven intervention evidence, overreliance on adult or male samples, and a lack of studies focused specifically on young adults in correctional settings.

A. Lack of agreed definition and measurement

Source 26

Citation: Sagara, B., et al. (2024). Mapping desistance research: A systematic quantitative literature review from 2011 to 2020.

Why relevant: This is one of your best synthesis sources for conceptual fragmentation.

Direct quote(s):

- “The increasing volume of literature on desistance has enhanced the knowledge of how and why offenders find a way out of their criminal activities; however, it has also led to variability in desistance research, causing problems in grasping a comprehensive picture of the desistance literature.”
- “The variability in desistance research is attributed to differing operationalisations of desistance.”
- “Primary desistance was the most commonly employed definition in desistance research.”
- “The follow up period for desistance research was generally less than 5 years.”

Brief summary: This review shows that even as desistance research expands, it remains conceptually fragmented. Different definitions, theories, and follow-up periods make the literature hard to synthesize.

Suggested use in writing: Use this as a recent synthesis source to justify your claim that the field still lacks a settled conceptual and methodological core.

Source 27

Citation: Massoglia, M., & Uggen, C. (2007). Subjective desistance and the transition to adulthood.

Why relevant: This is strong empirical evidence that the measured predictors of desistance depend on how desistance is defined.

Direct quote(s):

- “The prevalence and the predictors of desistance vary with these alternative conceptualizations.”

Brief summary: This study directly demonstrates that changing the operationalization changes the findings. That is one of the clearest ways to justify your methodological caution in Chapter 1.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to support a sentence like: because desistance has been operationalized in multiple, non-equivalent ways, findings across studies are not always directly comparable.

Source 28

Citation: Robertson, A. A., et al. (2022). Recidivism Among Justice-Involved Youth: Findings From JJ-TRIALS.

Why relevant: This source provides direct language for the recidivism-measurement problem.

Direct quote(s):

- “No consensus exists with respect to defining recidivism or the length of follow-up period for determining occurrences of recidivism.”

Brief summary: Because recidivism is often used as a proxy for failed desistance, inconsistency in recidivism measurement also weakens desistance conclusions.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to connect desistance measurement problems to broader justice-outcome measurement problems.

B. Limited evidence specific to young adults in correctional settings

Source 29

Citation: David, D. L., et al. (2016). Reducing recidivism and symptoms in emerging adults with serious mental health conditions and justice system involvement.

Why relevant: This is one of the most direct sources for the young-adult intervention gap.

Direct quote(s):

- “There are really no established interventions with evidence of efficacy to reduce recidivism among emerging adults with or without SMHC.”
- “All current approaches to curve recidivism have moderate effects on recidivism, but the efficacy of these approaches specifically with emerging adults is either unknown or less potent.”

Brief summary: This source gives you exactly the dissertation-relevant gap: there is little strong intervention evidence specifically for emerging adults, even though this population is developmentally distinct.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source in your gap statement or near the end of the section to justify why a developmentally tailored program is needed.

Source 30

Citation: Rice, S. M., et al. (2023). Unmet mental health and criminogenic needs among justice-involved young people: A role for clinicians in the community.

Why relevant: This source sharpens the developmental-service mismatch point.

Direct quote(s):

- “Many justice involved young ppl living in the community fall through systemic cracks, often magnified by the mismatch b/w developmental (10-25) and legal definitions of this population.”
- “Justice involved young ppl are less likely to engage with mental health services than young ppl who are not justice involved.”
- “Opportunities to provide evidence based mental health intervention to address unmet needs among this group must be prioritized in efforts to better support their transition to attainment of prosocial adult role functioning.”

Brief summary: Rice et al. show that justice-involved young people occupy a developmental category that is poorly matched to existing legal and service systems. This directly supports the need for age-responsive intervention design.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to show that the problem is not only individual risk, but systemic failure to provide developmentally appropriate care.

C. Overreliance on theory-light or risk-only approaches

Source 31

Citation: Ward, T. (2020). Why theory matters in correctional psychology: Theoretical illiteracy and therapeutic ineffectiveness.

Why relevant: This source gives you a sharp critique of relying on predictive models without explanatory depth.

Direct quote(s):

- “A legacy of this lack of attention to a deeper theoretical analysis of dynamic risk factors is that we are not sure exactly HOW therapy is contributing to reduction in recidivism.”
- “Prediction has been mistaken for explanation.”
- “Treatment targets are often selected without demonstrating causal relevance.”
- “The field risks therapeutic inefficacy due to weak theoretical foundations.”

Brief summary: Ward argues that correctional psychology often overrelies on conceptually thin risk-management models. This is highly relevant to your dissertation because it supports the need for theory-driven program development rather than merely risk-focused case management.

Suggested use in writing: Use this source to justify why your proposed manual should be theoretically integrated and not just an assortment of risk-management techniques.

D. Underrepresentation of women and limited gender-responsive evidence

Source 32

Citation: Silva, M. J., et al. (2025). Effectiveness of Motivational Interviewing with justice-involved people: A systematic review and meta-analysis.

Why relevant: This source directly identifies the underdevelopment of women-focused intervention research.

Direct quote(s):

- “This highlights the urgent need for more research focusing exclusively on women and for interventions aimed directly at women.”
- “Studying the specificities of female criminality is essential for developing and implementing effective mechanisms that cater to women’s unique requirements.”

Brief summary: Even where treatment evidence exists, much of it is generalized from male samples. That makes the literature less informative for gender-responsive correctional programming.

Suggested use in writing: Use this point to strengthen your discussion of gender limitations in the desistance literature.

Strongest sources to lean on in writing

If you want the strongest, most defensible core set for this section, I’d lean hardest on these:

- 1 Maruna / Maruna & Farrall — for defining desistance as a process and distinguishing primary vs. secondary desistance.
- 2 McNeill — for tertiary desistance, belonging, and reintegration.

- 3 Sagara et al. (2024) — for a recent synthesis showing conceptual fragmentation in the field.
- 4 Massoglia & Uggen (2007) — for the measurement problem and young-adult relevance.
- 5 Copp et al. (2020) — for one of the best empirical demonstrations that identity change and social ties jointly shape desistance during the transition to adulthood.
- 6 Mowen et al. (2018) — for family conflict, peers, and reentry context.
- 7 Lipsey & Cullen (2007) — for the broad rehabilitation evidence and the limits of punitive approaches.
- 8 David et al. (2016) — for the emerging-adult-specific intervention gap and preliminary support for developmentally tailored intervention.
- 9 Rice et al. (2023) — for developmental mismatch, unmet needs, and age-responsive service implications.
- 10 Ward (2020) — for the critique of theory-light correctional intervention and support for deeper conceptual grounding.

Gap areas to emphasize in the dissertation

These are the best gap statements to emphasize at the end of Section 4 and later in the Chapter 1 gap/rationale section:

1. No settled definition of desistance

The field still lacks consensus on whether desistance is best conceptualized as behavioral nonoffending, identity transformation, social reintegration, or some combination of all three.

2. No settled measurement strategy

Studies vary in whether they use arrests, convictions, reincarceration, self-report offending, subjective desistance, or follow-up duration. That means findings across studies are not always directly comparable.

3. Tertiary desistance is underdeveloped

Most studies emphasize primary desistance, fewer examine secondary desistance, and very little work addresses tertiary desistance and social belonging.

4. Young adults are understudied as a distinct population

Emerging adults often get folded into either juvenile or adult frameworks even though the developmental literature shows that ages roughly 18–25/26 represent a distinct transition period.

5. Few intervention studies are designed specifically for justice-involved emerging adults

The literature repeatedly notes that there are very few established, evidence-based interventions with demonstrated efficacy for reducing recidivism/desistance problems specifically in emerging adults.

6. Correctional settings are especially underexamined

There is a major gap in literature on developmentally tailored, evidence-based desistance-promoting programs for young adults in correctional/residential settings, which is exactly where your dissertation/manual sits.

7. Gender-responsive desistance/intervention evidence remains thin

Much of the research is still male-dominated, and there is not enough women-specific or gender-responsive intervention evidence.

8. Theory and practice are still not well integrated

The literature supports rehabilitation broadly, but there is still a disconnect between desistance theory, developmental science, criminogenic-need evidence, and practical intervention design for young adults in custody or residential care.

Bottom-line synthesis you can adapt into the chapter

A strong concluding paragraph for this section would say something like:

The desistance literature increasingly supports understanding crime cessation as a dynamic process involving behavioral change, identity transformation, and social reintegration. However, the field remains limited by inconsistent definitions and measurement, underdevelopment of tertiary desistance research, and a lack of intervention studies focused specifically on emerging adults in correctional settings. These gaps are especially important because emerging adulthood is a distinct developmental period in which identity, social bonds, treatment engagement, and transition into prosocial adult roles may be especially consequential. Accordingly, there is a strong rationale for developing developmentally responsive, theory-informed interventions aimed at promoting desistance among young adults in correctional or residential contexts.